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The Cost of a Click: Why Public Shaming is Destroying Adolescent Mental Health

In our society, we know that everyone deserves respect, dignity, and a fair chance to prove who they really are on the inside. From a young age, we teach our children that mistakes are not only normal but beneficial, as it shows that the individual is trying their best and testing their full potential. However, in the digital world, this cultural assumption is ignored. Social media and the implementation of public shaming for personal benefit have created a harmful environment for all of its users. Younger generations are especially vulnerable to this manipulation because of their developing cognitive abilities and malleable perspectives. Authors such as Monica Lewinsky, who has experienced such harm, expose the public dangers that the online environment has introduced. Online shaming is no longer a byproduct of the digital world; it has become a moral crisis that corrupt online platforms have built upon for financial benefit. These environments are engineered to amplify humiliation and other distressing content, creating constant pressures that reshape the working minds of teenagers and adults alike, often dismantling their sense of self-worth.

Many teenagers find social media to be overwhelming and addictive due to the massive volume of distressing content that prevents young people from recovering mentally or emotionally from their own experiences. When a student or a kid makes a mistake offline, it could eventually fade away and be forgotten. On the other hand, when a mistake occurs online, it becomes trapped in a permanent loop. The speed and visibility of online humiliation can intensify emotions of regret or self-shaming, even from the simplest errors by individuals who are still figuring out their personal identities.

Monica Lewinsky is a primary witness to the pandemic of public shaming. In her speech, *The Price of Shame*, she reflects on her own experience of how she made mistakes in her youth and how they were weaponized once they reached the internet. She also highlights another example of a young man who was secretly recorded doing a private activity, properly and with consent, who eventually takes his own life due to his online shame. “Tyler’s tragic, senseless death was a turning point for me. It served to recontextualize my experiences.” (Lewinsky 10:48). Lewinsky informs the audience and all watchers to take on their responsibility to make the world a better place by showing respect to everyone as they would expect to be treated. Her unmatched ethos makes her a very credible source in explaining the reality from the eyes of a victim.

Her argument is very understandable to me, who grew up with social media as an easy form of entertainment. I have found a similar result to Monica Lewinsky; every post feels directed towards the audience, rather than the author’s personal expression. Social media has been found to amplify small errors into massive, circulating, humiliating ones. This connects to our current society through two powerful examples that can not be argued, as they are true events that the internet has solidified into the media. Her work also includes her raw emotions as she speaks the truth and her online persona with it.

Social media platforms often argue that the harm comes from poor user habits or a lack of parental guidance rather than the platforms themselves. They argue that if users were to practice better self-control, the crisis would lessen, if not drop completely. This perspective comes from the idea that the online space is a neutral environment where users have full power over their choices. Responsibility is often shifted to the parents, who are expected to limit their students' social media time and teach them safer habits to protect their mental and emotional health. However, this argument relies on the assumption that individual structure is powerful enough to counter the engineered platform’s persuasion to brainwash its users. UC Davis Health explains, the “addictive nature of social media activates the brain’s reward center by releasing dopamine,” (UC Davis Health, 3), creating a psychological cycle that is difficult

to break. In addition, Katella notes, “frequent social media use may be associated with distinct changes in the developing brain” (Katella, 1), suggesting that these platforms are not neutral entertainment but actively conditioning the minds of our youth.

This structural harm is compounded and multiplied by the algorithms within these applications. As Katella from Yale Medicine explains in her article “How Social Media Affects Your Teen’s Mental Health: A Parent’s Guide”, social media algorithms are designed to maximize social engagement by exposing teens to distressing content. They have found that by keeping youth in a constant state of anger or anxiety, they can ensure that users continue to scroll due to the emotional conditioning and mental retraining. Lewinsky points out that this is not a generational anomaly, but a feature of everyday digital life. This is supported by Yale Medicine’s experts, who warn parents of the harm of their teen interacting with distressing content such as posts about self-harm, as platforms “may begin flooding their feed with similar content.” (Katella, 5) Especially late at night while doomscrolling, this can distort the reality around these young adolescents and lead to possible mental disorders.

To connect with Lewinsky’s idea of how public shaming can “haunt” a person endlessly, UC Davis Health provides evidence supporting the psychological toll of this social environment. UC Davis Health explains that the “addictive nature of social media activates the brain’s reward center by releasing dopamine” (UC Davis, 3); however, when the scrolling stops, the brain loses the constant false dopamine boosts and becomes drained. This mirrors the pressures that Lewinsky experienced, where the lack of an “off” switch induced a constant “fight or flight” response, forcing her to live off adrenaline—an exhausting state. UC Davis describes social media as a “highlight reel” (UC Davis, 7) composed of others’ “perfect lives” (UC Davis, 7) and peak experiences. The comparison often triggers self-shaming, which can descend into depression or learned helplessness in some people when they conclude that their lives are nothing compared to what they see online. These individuals who feel behind are sometimes just as harmed as those who fall victim to online humiliation. Additionally, when victims are exposed to their own shaming content, their trauma wounds reopen in more ways

than emotional instability; this harm is compounded by the algorithm's ability to fuel anxiety, making the online environment an inescapable prison. Once a harmless mistake hits the surface of the internet, it can be constantly brought back to life at any time for public consumption.

Lewinsky identifies this uncontrollable visibility as “The Price of Shame.” This is reinforced by Gail Duffy from Ethos Treatment, who states that the digital age has transformed harassment abilities into a more exploitative version. In her article, “The Silent Threat: How Social Media Turns Bullying into an Unescapable Reality,” Duffy argues that while traditional bullying was once confined to real-world spaces, the removed boundaries make digital harassment “uniquely invasive.” (Duffy, 2) The fact that “social media can allow bullies to hide behind anonymous accounts” (Duffy, 4) allows online bullies to never face consequences for their actions. This directly supports a key note from Lewinsky that online shaming is a permanent “blood sport” (Lewinsky 17:22). The next person who is targeted as social media’s “attention grabber” never gets the ability to move on; instead, they are forced to relive the “haunting” (Lewinsky 18:10) loss of their reputation. Duffy confirms that the ability for bullies to “hide behind anonymous accounts” (Duffy, Gail) ensures that the harm remains constant, consequence-free. Synthesizing Duffy’s clinical perspective with Lewinsky’s personal narrative reveals the systematic dismantling of the victim's ability to live in the present, as the past is always visible, and the future will always include the now permanent past.

Ultimately, Lewinsky’s TED Talk pushes the audience to consider the social consequences of their digital footprints before engaging in online activity. Her speech, supported with recent clinical research, challenges the toxic cultural assumption that public humiliation is a “deserved” consequence for human error. She reminds the audience that every person deserves second chances, along with compassion and respect from their peers. Cruelty only spreads when there is a financial benefit involved. This raises a fundamental question: if our society values human dignity, why is that dignity disregarded in the digital space? This

message is critical in today's society as an anchor for young people to understand the true meanings of identity and self-worth, independent from the money-seeking, algorithm-driven, and manipulative online environment.

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